Nisha Devasia

ndevasia@uw.edu ndevasia ndevasia.github.io

EDUCATION

University of Washington — **Seattle, WA**
PhD Candidate, Human Centered Design and Engineering — *2025 - 2028*
Committee: Julie Kientz, Jin Ha Lee, Safinah Ali, Sean Munson, R. Benjamin Shapiro (GSR)

University of Washington — **Seattle, WA**
M.S in Human Centered Design and Engineering — *2023 - 2025*

Massachusetts Institute of Technology — **Cambridge, MA**
S.B. in Computer Science & S.B. in Comparative Media Studies — *2017 - 2021*

PUBLICATIONS

Journal Articles

[J.8] **Devasia N.**, Newman M., Ali S., Kientz J., & Lee J.H. (2026). SAVEstate: A Method for Documenting Player Reflection in Digital Games. Upcoming in *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction*. To be presented at *CHI PLAY '26*.

[J.7] Russo E., **Devasia N.**, & Hiniker A. (2026). How Romantic Partners Build "Sound Relationship Houses" through Shared Gaming. Upcoming in *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction*. To be presented at *CHI PLAY '26*.

[J.6] Newman M., Zhao R., Hu S., Gasperina I., **Devasia N.**, Windleharth T., Rubin J., Lee J.H., & Yip J. (2026). Documentation in Play: A Framework for Collaborative Evidence Construction in Inquiry-Based Games. Upcoming in *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction*. To be presented at *CHI PLAY '26*.

[J.5] **Devasia N.**, Espinosa-Briones J., & Kientz J. (2026). A Systematic Review of Narrative Game-based Interventions for Mental Health. *ACM Transactions on Computing for Healthcare*.

[J.4] **Devasia N.**, Kenderova G., Newman M., Kientz J., & Lee J.H (2025). 'I Would Not Be This Version of Myself Today': Elaborating on the Effects of Eudaimonic Gaming Experiences. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction, 9(6)*. Presented in *CHI PLAY '25*.

[J.3] **Devasia N.** & Lee J.H. (2024). The role of narrative in misinformation games. In *Harvard Kennedy School (HKS) Misinformation Review, 5(5)*.

[J.2] Williams R., Ali S., **Devasia N.**, DiPaola D., Hong J., Kaputsos S., Jordan B., & Breazeal C. (2022). AI + Ethics Curricula for Middle School Youth: Lessons Learned from Three Project-Based Curricula. In *International Journal of Artificial Intelligence in Education*.

[J.1] Ali S., **Devasia N**., Park HW., & Breazeal C. (2021). Social Robots as Creativity Eliciting Agents. In *Frontiers in Robotics and AI 2021; 8: 673730*.

Peer Reviewed Conference Proceedings

[C.9] **Devasia N.**, Bugre C., Morse L., Coward C., & Lee J.H. (2026). Mission Viral: Co-Designing a Misinformation Education Game with West African Librarians. Upcoming in *Proceedings of the 89th Annual Meeting of the Association for Information Science & Technology (ASIS&T '26)*.

[C.8] Dangol A., Wolfe R., **Devasia N.**, Kiyohara M., Yip J., & Kientz J. (2026). Where Does AI Leave a Footprint? Children's Reasoning About AI's Environmental Costs. *Proceedings of the 2026 Conference for Interaction Design and Children (IDC '26)*.

[C.7] **Devasia N.**, Rodriguez A., Tuttle L., & Kientz J. (2025). Partnership through Play: Investigating How Long-Distance Couples Use Digital Games to Facilitate Intimacy. *Proceedings of the 2025 Designing Interactive Systems Conference (DIS '25)*.

[C.6] Coward C., **Devasia N.**, & Lee J.H. (2025). Escape Rooms for Misinformation Education: A Case Study of Co-design with Two Communities. *Proceedings of the 2025 Digital Games Research Association Conference (DiGRA '25)*.

[C.5] **Devasia N.**, Zhao R., & Lee. J.H. (2025). Does the Story Matter? Applying Narrative Theory to an Educational Misinformation Escape Room Game. In *Proceedings of the 2025 Annual Symposium on Computer-Human Interaction* (*CHI '25*).

[C.4] Rodriguez A., **Devasia N.**, Pei M., & Kientz J. (2024). Towards Construction-Oriented Play for Vision-Diverse People. In *Proceedings of the 26th International ACM SIGACCESS Conference on Computers and Accessibility* (*ASSETS '24*).

[C.3] **Devasia N**., Figueroa A., Evans S., Herman B., & Aragon C. (2024). Student Perspectives on Learning and Teaching Data Ethics Through Speculative Game Design. In *Proceedings of the 17th International Conference on Computer-Supported Collaborative Learning* (*CSCL '24*).

[C.2] (**Honorable Mention Award**) Ali S. and **Devasia N**., & Breazeal C. (2022). Escape!Bot: Social Robots as Creative Problem-Solving Partners. In *Proceedings of ACM Creativity and Cognition 2022* (*C&C '22*).

[C.1] Jordan B., **Devasia N**., Hong J., Williams R., & Breazeal C. (2021). PoseBlocks: A Toolkit for Creating (and Dancing) with AI. In *Eleventh AAAI Symposium on Educational Advances in Artificial Intelligence* (*EAAI-21*).

Organized Workshops

[O.3] Wemmer, E., Dhiman, H., Sun, Y., **Devasia, N.**, Campbell, A.V., Väkevä, J., Endlicher, E., Fellmann, M., Röcker, C., Niess, J., Woźniak, P., & Diefenbach, S (2026). The Many Facets of Eudaimonia: Bridging the Gap Between Theory and Design Perspectives. *15th Nordic Conference on Human Computer Interaction* (*NordiCHI '26*).

[O.2] Landesman, R., Tare, M., Divanji, R., Rubin, J., Everson, J., Dangol, A., & **Devasia, N.** (2026). Frameworks in the Field: Considering Real Life Tensions When Designing AI for Children's Well-being. *Interaction Design and Children 25th Conference* (*IDC '26*).

[O.1] **Devasia, N.**, Coward, C., & Lee, J.H. (2025). Misinfo Madness: Rapid Ideation and Design of an Educational Misinformation Escape Room Game. *NextLibrary Festival 2025*.

Book Chapters

[B.3] **Devasia N.**. "I Am Your Living Legacy": Readings from a Lifelong Journey with Final Fantasy VII. *Well Played: Well Read Games, 15*(*1*). Carnegie Mellon University: Play Story Press.

[B.2] **Devasia N**., (*in prep*). Shinra at the Intersection of Science, Technology, and Society. *The Psychgeist of Pop Culture: Final Fantasy VII*. Carnegie Mellon University: Play Story Press.

[B.1] **Devasia N**. Domesticating Bliss: Facilitating Long Distance Relationships Through Virtual Play. *The Psychgeist of Pop Culture: Stardew Valley*. Carnegie Mellon University: Play Story Press.

Extended Abstracts

[A.4] **Devasia N.** (2026). Scaffolding Reflection in Games for Eudaimonic Well-being. Upcoming in *Companion Proceedings of the 2026 Annual Symposium on Computer-Human Interaction in Play* (*CHI PLAY '26*).

[A.3] **Devasia N.**, Espinosa-Briones J., & Kientz J. (2025). Preliminary Results from a Systematic Review of Narrative Game-based Interventions for Mental Health. *Abstract Proceedings of the 2025 Digital Games Research Association Conference* (*DiGRA '25*).

[A.2] Pande M., Moran R., Lee J.H., Kientz J., Yarborough S., **Devasia N.**, & Symonds L. (2025). A PILOT TRIAL OF AN ESCAPE ROOM GAME TO COMBAT CANCER NUTRITION MISINFORMATION. *Abstracts of Multinational Association of Supportive Care in Cancer* (*MASCC '25*).

[A.1] **Devasia N**., Ali S., & Breazeal C. (2020). Escape!Bot: Child-Robot Interaction to Promote Creative Expression During Gameplay. In *Extended Abstracts of the 2020 Annual Symposium on Computer-Human Interaction in Play* (*CHI PLAY '20*).

Workshop Submissions

[W.3] **Devasia N.** (2025). What are we talking about when we talk about escapism? Workshop on Exploring Future Directions for Healthy Escapism and Self-Regulation in Games. *Annual Symposium on Computer-Human Interaction in Play* (*CHI PLAY '25*).

[W.2] Ali S. and **Devasia N.**, & Breazeal C. (2021). Designing Games for Enabling Co-creation with Social Agents. Workshop on Designing Games for and with Children: Co-design Methodologies for playful activities using AR/VR and Social Agents. *ACM/IEEE Interaction Design and Children Conference 2021 (IDC-21)*.

[W.1] Ali S., **Devasia N.**, & Breazeal C. (2021). Building Child-Robot Collaborative Relationships in Creative Interactions. Workshop on Measuring Child Robot Relationships. *ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction 2021 (HRI-21)*.

Posters

[P.2] Yoon, S., Evans, S., Aragon, C., Herman, B., **Devasia, N.**, Miles, T. (2024). Responsibility and Care in AI/ML Education: A Collaborative Approach to Ethical Awareness. *Association for Information Science and Technology 2024 (ASIS&T '24)*.

[P.1] **Devasia N.** & Lee J.H. (2024) The Role of Narrative in Misinformation Games. *Trust and Safety Research Conference (T&S '24)*.

FUNDED GRANTS WITH KEY CONTRIBUTIONS

- **HCDE Doctoral Grant (University of Washington)** **Award Amount: $500**
  Connecting Eudaimonic Game Experiences to Theories of Behavior Change *2024*
  Nisha Devasia (Key personnel & Lead proposal writer), Jin Ha Lee (PI), Julie Kientz (PI)
- **CIP Innovation Fund (University of Washington)** **Award Amount: $4200**
  Effect of Transportation and Identification on Learning Outcomes in a Misinformation Education Game *2024*
  Nisha Devasia (Key personnel & Lead proposal writer), Jin Ha Lee (PI), Chris Coward (PI)

TEACHING & MENTORING

Teaching

- Graduate Teaching Assistant for HCDE 438 (Web Technologies), Spring 2026
- Instructor for Amazon Future Engineer, Summer 2020
- New Hampshire Girls' Math Circle, 2014-2016

Mentoring

- CSE 494 (Guided Research in Computer Science and Engineering), Winter and Spring 2026 (Mentees: J. Kowal, N. Tian, K. Lin, M. Jo)
- DUB REU program, Summer 2024 (Mentees: N. Gorkar, J. Espinosa-Briones)
- Twitch Intern program, Summer 2023 (Mentee: K. Dhamnait)
- Resident Peer Mentor at MIT, Fall 2020
- Project Scientist, Summer 2019
- Associate Advisor at MIT, 2018-2019

Directed Research Groups

- Developing a Digital Diary Application, Winter and Spring 2025
- Facilitating Long-Distance Connection through Gaming, Spring 2024

SERVICE

- **Organizing Committee**: IDC 2027 (Web Chair); CHI PLAY 2026 (Social Media & Publicity Chair)
- **Associate Chair**: CHI PLAY WIP 2026
- **Reviewer**: ISLS 2024, CHI 2025-2026, DIS 2025-2026, NeurIPS-25 Education, ACM HEALTH 2026, IDC 2026, IJCCI 2026, CHI PLAY 2026
- Student Coordinator for UW Center for Digital Youth, Fall 2023 to present
- Program Advisory Committee for B.S. in Computer Science and Engineering, DigiPen Institute, Spring 2023
- Intern Review Committee for Twitch University Recruiting, September 2022 to September 2023
- Technical Interviewer for Twitch University Recruiting, September 2022 to September 2023
- Educational Counselor for MIT, Fall 2021 to present

RESEARCH POSITIONS

foundry10 — **Seattle, Washington**
Graduate Student Researcher — *October 2025 - present*
- Assisting with ideation, prototyping, and data collection on a number of foundry10 research projects.
- Running a game book club program and research initiative in local libraries.

University of Tokyo (IIS Lab) — **Tokyo, Japan**
Visiting Graduate Researcher — *June 2026 - September 2026*
- Investigating how scaffolding reflection in games can contribute to perceptions of well-being and meaningfulness.

MIT Media Lab (Personal Robots) — **Cambridge, Massachusetts**
Research Assistant — *January 2021 - June 2021*
- Deployed Escape!Bot study to 50 schoolchildren aged 5-11 in the greater New England area. Conducted study sessions with teammate, analyzed results, and published paper in ACM C&C '22.
- Co-wrote short papers and workshop posters in IDC and HRI surrounding work on social robots and creativity.
- Conducted teacher trainings for Dancing with AI curriculum, which teachers then deployed to their students around the country.

Undergraduate Researcher — *January 2019 - January 2021*
- Designed and built a 2D platformer game in Unity and C# to measure creativity in elementary school children.
- Ran study sessions and compiled results for graduate student's work on creative social robots.
- Developed and piloted an interactive AI curriculum for middle schoolers through the Amazon Future Engineer program.
- Wrote curriculum and designed prototype for online textbook to teach K-12 schoolchildren about GANs.
- Helped build and maintain raise.mit.edu, the front page of MIT's multidisciplinary AI education initiative.

The Education Arcade — **Cambridge, Massachusetts**
Undergraduate Researcher — *June 2018 - August 2018*
- Designed, prototyped, and implemented features for TaleBlazer, a location-based AR smartphone app.
- Implemented highly requested time dependent features for online editor using a Javascript frontend.

INDUSTRY AND OTHER POSITIONS

Twitch — **San Francisco, California**
Software Engineer II — *August 2022 - September 2023*
- Self-initiated improvements to baremetal workflows, including piloting addition of integration tests to baremetal services.
- Rearchitecting legacy baremetal services using Amazon Builder Tools and AWS.

Software Engineer I — *August 2021 - July 2022*
- Architected, coded, and built multi-component monitoring service for detecting abrupt drops in network traffic using AWS SQS, Kinesis, ECS, and Apache Druid.
- Designed and implemented distributed locking system for polling daemon using AWS DynamoDB.
- Wrote from scratch and maintained team's deployment runbooks, as well as several service and onboarding documents.

Software Engineering Intern — *June 2020 - August 2020*
- Refactored polling protocol in Golang to receive 1.5x more data per minute at no change to costs, providing better approximation of network traffic for video system.
- Created and owned pipeline that tracks live CDN utilization metrics, using AWS Lambda, Kinesis, and CloudWatch.

Education Development Center — **Remote**
Curriculum Designer — *December 2020 - March 2021*
- Developed data science integrated curricula for biology, physics, and chemistry.
- Co-designed lessons and activities with educators. Curricula will be used by the State of Massachusetts.

PlayStation (Santa Monica Studio) — **Los Angeles, California**
Engine Programming Intern — *May 2019 - August 2019*
- Revamped studio-wide debugging tool using modern rendering package to increase usability and productivity.
- Gained C++ and system design experience creating pipeline tools for a triple A video game studio.

MIT Admissions — **Cambridge, Massachusetts**
Admissions Blogger — *September 2017 - January 2021*
- Blogged about student life to thousands of potential applicants.
- Provided feedback to MIT Admissions and act as an ambassador for MIT to the general public.

AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

- CERES Scholar, Jacobs Foundation, 2024-2025
- Scholarship to CRA-WP Grad Cohort for Women, 2024
- Academic All-Conference Team, Northeast Fencing Conference, 2021
- XBox Women in Gaming Scholar, 2020
- Rewriting the Code Fellow, 2019
- National Merit Scholar, 2017
- State AP Scholar and National AP Scholar, College Board, 2016
- Reischauer Scholar, Stanford University, 2016
- Japan-America Friendship Scholar, Youth for Understanding, 2016
- 2x National Semifinalist, North American Computational Linguistics Olympiad, 2015 and 2016
- Math Prize for Girls, Advantage Testing Foundation, 2015
- Distinguished Honor Roll (top 1% of test takers), American Math Competitions, 2015
- 2x AIME qualifier, Mathematical Association of America, 2014 and 2015

INVITED TALKS & PRESENTATIONS

- **Partnership through Play: Investigating How Long Distance Couples Use Digital Games to Facilitate Intimacy**. ITU Copenhagen. 2025.
- **Games and Child-Computer Interaction**. Guest Lecture for INFO 498A at University of Washington. 2025.
- **Games and Misinformation**. Guest Lecture for HONS 1830W-69 at Vanderbilt University. Remote, 2024.
- **Introduction to PoseBlocks**. GirlsInAI2021 Hackathon - India. Remote, 2021.
- **Interning Remotely**. Jameel World Education Lab (J-WEL). Remote, 2020.

SELECTED MEDIA COVERAGE

- **GeekWire**: From stress relief to self-discovery: UW researchers reveal the deeper impact of video games. [link] (My research made it onto GeekWire!)
- **UW News**: Q&A: How video games can lead people to more meaningful lives. [link] (University-wide news article covering my PhD research)
- **MIT School of Engineering**: Love of the game. [link] (student spotlight covering my undergraduate research)
- **Santa Monica Studio**: Inspiring a New Generation. [link] (interviewed as part of STEM outreach team)
- **Daily Mail UK**: [link] One of my student blog posts went infamously viral and made it to the tabloids.

SKILLS & CERTIFICATIONS

- **Skills**: Software Engineering, GoLang, Game/Interaction Design, Unity3D, Python, Java, C#, Writing, Blogging
- **Coursera Certifications**: Getting and Cleaning Data, R Programming, UW Machine Learning Certification
- **Other Certifications**: Japanese Language Placement Test N2 (full professional fluency)